the customer base by 10% within a year" is similar, though the connection with generating revenue is slightly more indirect. "Avoid losing existing customers" is an example of protecting revenue, whereas the fourth, "Reduce hotline costs," is clearly about reducing costs.

An example of avoiding future costs might be implementing certain reports that will be required by new legislation due to take effect next year. In this case, you're investing effort now in order to avoid fines for noncompliance in the future.

Business goals in a public service organization—Transport for NSW

Transport for NSW, the government agency responsible for public transport in New South Wales, Australia, recently implemented a project to provide Google Maps with real-time scheduling information for trains and buses, as is done in many large cities around the world. Travellers can use Google Maps not only to find public transport options between two locations, but also to find out when the next bus or train is scheduled to arrive, based on real-time data coming from the buses and trains.

There's no profit motivation here: the aim is to allow public transport passengers to be able to use the public transport network more efficiently and reduce the time passengers need to wait for public transport. The motivation behind this may be increasing customer satisfaction. Happier passengers are more likely to use this service instead of any alternatives. A secondary goal could be to save people time, freeing them up for more productive work, which in turn benefits the local economy. This project will generate no increased revenue for the government agency implementing the project.

This rule still holds true for government or non-profit organizations, but in a slightly modified form. Public services, for example, are not as interested in generating revenue as they are in providing valuable services to the public. This type of organization also typically has an externally defined budget: the service is responsible for how taxpayer dollars are spent, so cost plays a critical role in business goals. In general, the business goals for projects in non-profit organizations tend to fall into the following categories:

- Improving service
- Reducing costs
- Avoiding future costs

EXERCISE 3.3 Identify some business goals that might be applicable to the bus subsidies project in the previous exercise. Propose concrete strategies to measure how well the application discussed in exercise 3.1 achieves these goals.

3.4.3 *Popping the "why stack": digging out the business goals*

If you want to build software that delivers real value to your customers, understanding the core business goals of a project is essential. Unfortunately, neither business sponsors nor end users typically express their needs in terms of pure business value. Instead, they talk in terms of concrete features or solutions that they have in mind. In